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Mind, Brain, and Meaning

Short Paper 2

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Psst! Steven Spielberg is Annoyed At You!

Imagine Steven Spielberg offered you a role in one of his movies and, after missing rehearsals and arriving late to set, he says, “It’s fine! If you don’t have time we can find someone else”. You’ve just been validated, “fine!”, and that your absence isn’t a problem, but you’d likely feel guilty receiving this sentence and it might even instill a desire to show up early to set every day. The art of reverse psychology is the practice of advocating for or encouraging something you want the opposite of; reverse psychology is helps demonstrate the separation yet interconnectedness of language, thought, and representation. Spielberg is upset with you and wants you to show up on set - that is his thought. Spielberg may not want to come off stern and, so, represents his thought in a way that makes it seem as though he is taking care of your needs although what he is encouraging defies his and your wants. Spielberg then uses language to communicate this to you in a way that you can understand grammatically and process that the suggestion has a negative connotation despite its neutral/arguably positive construction. While language, thought, and representation all have different roles in this hypothetical communication, they all inform one another. Essentially, thoughts serve as one’s internal meanings or understanding, language is how that thought is communicated pragmatically, and representation is the bridge between these two, a manipulation or communication of thought in preparation for the deliverance of that thought. In other words, representation describes the way language is used and has awareness of how language will be understood concerning the speaker’s thought.

Firstly, language, thought, and representation as three separate ideas must be clarified to justify that they are all somewhat distinct and that the aforementioned bridge relationship can exist. In lecture 9, we discussed three different types of aphasia: Broca’s aphasia, Wernicke’s aphasia, and conduction aphasia (L9, Slide 9). Broca’s aphasia is identified by impaired speech production coupled with relatively

intact comprehension and intelligence and Wernicke's aphasia is characterized by impaired intelligibility and comprehension but fluent speech production; this shows us the separation between thought and language. Conduction aphasia is characterized by relatively preserved speech production and comprehension, separately (L9, Slides 12-18). The condition becomes most evident when asking an afflicted individual to repeat information—a task that requires a bridge between comprehension and production. The video on slide 19 of lecture 9 shows a man who can repeat singular words when prompted, but, when asked to string each of the individual words to form a sentence, is unable to do so. The man may know what each of the words are individually but he is unable to manipulate that information in a way in which he can communicate the answer to the interviewer's question. We can see this failure to bridge internal understanding and language as a failure to form representations. Now that we have entertained language, speech, and representation as three separate mental processes, we will discuss their interaction in communication.

Language is the most externally facing part of the three steps I've mentioned in the process of communication. By externally facing, I mean language, for communication, is chosen based on the representation of an internal thought with a social context in mind and is expressed either vocally or written for others to see or hear. Pinker's understanding of language implicitly agrees with this, "The way language works, then, is that each person's brain contains a lexicon of words and the concepts they stand for (a mental dictionary) and a set of rules that combine the words to convey relationships among concepts (a mental grammar)" (Pinker, 76). Concepts are essentially thoughts, the representation of those concepts are dictated by the "lexicon of words" and categories and concepts a person gains from experience, and the product, language, is a set of rules that dictates how we can create relationships between concepts. This creation of relationships between concepts seems to hint at the external-facing nature of language—why would we need to create relationships between established and shared concepts and our thoughts if not to communicate, explain, or be understood?

The process I described earlier, from initial thought to delivery through language, has the purpose of communication in mind. Language is a social and shared thing. In lecture 6, we discussed that ways of

understanding language systems, like as a generative grammar system or a context-free phrase structure grammar, must not allow for utterances that are not used (L6, Slide 21). This emphasis on “use” hints at the pragmatic nature of transforming thought into language. Processing and comprehension is a major goal and use of expression through language so it makes sense that we may need the manipulation of thought before we can use language to make our speech receivable. While the meaning of sentences, units of language (Chierchia, 70), may be thought of more literally as being tied to a representation through syntax and semantics, the meaning of a sentence can also be dedicated by the speaker’s intentional or social meaning (L7, Slide 25). H.P Grice’s cooperative principle outlines this: “Make your conversational contribution such as is required, at the stage at which it occurs, by the accepted purpose or direction of the talk exchange in which you are engaged” (L7, Slide 26).

In the context of communication, viewing the meaning of language as intentional and social helps us see why representation is so important as the bridge between thought and language. One of Grice’s maxims of communication, relation, can be used to illustrate the manipulation of thought into representation: a software engineer will explain the general use and benefit of the new software they are building to their CEO and marketing team instead of using highly technical concepts they likely called on to generate the idea. The great relevance of the technical aspect of the new product to the software engineer is irrelevant to non-technical teams at this hypothetical company, so to avoid confusion and effectively communicate with their CEO, the engineer considers the context and their relation to their audience. Additionally, we can use Grice’s manner maxim to understand why spoken poetry may be a beautiful art form, but an ineffective form of communication. If the social context is a business meeting, and someone chooses to represent the meanings of their thoughts in a poetically—liberal use of pauses, flowery language, etc—, the speech may be labeled non-sequitur or gibberish. While the meaning may be hidden within the spoken poem, how business analytics are being conveyed does not match the social context, leading to a lack of understanding. Similarly, to revisit our Steven Spielberg example, if you weren’t enthused to be a part of this hypothetical movie, and you weren’t aware of Spielberg’s reputation, Spielberg’s reverse psychology would be the inappropriate manner of communication.

Works Cited

Gennaro Chierchia, and Sally McConnell-Ginet. 2000. *Meaning and Grammar : An Introduction to Semantics*. Cambridge, Mass: Mit Press.

Pinker, Steven. 1994. *The Language Instinct: The New Science of Language and Mind*. London: Penguin Books, Impr.